

Survival of the geekiest

How things have changed. Just over a decade ago, the term “geek” was used as an insult – it sometimes still is, but usually by someone of no importance and a huge chip on his shoulder. For most of us, the word is now associated with Mark Zuckerberg, Brin and Page or, perhaps Bill Gates.

Most of us reading this magazine would proudly wear a T-shirt that proclaims, “The Geek shall inherit the Earth”, and it will be true as well.

So what really is a “Geek”? Merriam-Webster, the Dictionary of our choice, defines a geek as:

A carnival performer often billed as a wild man whose act usually includes biting the head off a live chicken or snake; a person often of an intellectual bent who is disliked; an enthusiast or expert especially in a technological field or activity <computer geek>

The third definition was the last to be added, and if we go by that one, then it's but obvious that the geek will indeed inherit the Earth. Why am I so sure? Because one look at the world around you will tell you that technical skills and computer knowledge is just about essential to get anywhere in the world today. It also assumes that by “inherit” we mean “control”, and by control, I mean control the money, of course.

It's simple logic to deduce that the evolution of mankind will take the path of the wealthy; they have better chances of survival, finding a mate and seeing their offspring into adulthood. Thus, even if we geeks don't inherit the Earth, we most certainly will breed everything else out of it, eventually. Is mankind destined to evolve from whatever it is now, into a society of geeks, leaving the non-geeky to fight for the scraps we choose to drop?

Perhaps, and that worries me. Who says geeks are any better than the rest of the world? Yes I know that Bill Gates gives billions of dollars away to charities, and some say Steve Jobs does not, but regardless of those facts or insinuations, the truth is that for every Dollar that Bill or Steve make, many, many more are made by the corporations that they represent...

This isn't a rant about evil corporations, neither is this a repeat of my views about how tech is devolving our skills. There always will be a market for those of us with “hard” skills such as carpenters, plumbers and the like – I should know, I'm paying through my nose for some

renovation work right now. For all we know, those with hard skills are probably on their way to becoming Google-enhanced, Microsoft-powered, carpenter geeks!

However, when discussing survival and evolution, it's important for all of us to realise that the roads less travelled are viable options. This month's cover story, for example, was conceived to show you how it's not necessary to lock your source code up in Fort Knox to protect it, or make money from it. Neither should you assume that on joining the Open Source movement you will grow your hair and beard long, smoke pot, and listen to the Beatles all day. Of course you might, but it will be of your own doing.

The main reason why I think Open Source is important in this context, is because none of us want a society of individuals who have evolved only from a heady mix of stock brokers, politicians and corporate employees. We just need to throw in a little “traditional geek” in there – the Stallman and Torvalds type – or else life would be incredibly boring... and expensive!

Thankfully, knowingly or unknowingly, India is ensuring that the evolution to geekdom is balanced. More and more people are embracing Open Source here in India, and that means more developers and technology innovators start working with it. A mere five years ago, people complained of not being able to find a PHP coder in India; in contrast, today the complaint is that they're crawling out of the woodwork, but quality needs to improve.

Somewhere along the line, we've become content to modify an OSS product to suit a client's needs, and charge for service, but we're not very keen on opening up our source code to public scrutiny. It's only when we get into the habit of building OSS products from scratch will we start making money as individuals, companies and a country.

I'd very much like for the evolved geek of the future (that master of all things technology, and all-round stud muffin) to be able to acknowledge the influences of the Indian Open Source Software Movement. Wouldn't you?



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A stylized, handwritten signature in black ink, likely belonging to Robert Sovereign-Smith.

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